

Chapter 1 — The Treatment

The lights in the lab flickered every couple seconds.

Not enough to shut anything down. Just enough to make everyone notice.

Machines hummed low through the walls while monitors beeped in uneven rhythms.

Somewhere deeper in the building, somebody laughed for half a second before the sound got swallowed by metal doors and ventilation fans. The whole place smelled like bleach, hot wires, and old coffee.

Markus Oakley stood beside the operating chair fixing the sleeve of his gloves.

Calm hands.

Calm face.

Like always.

The patient sitting in front of him looked terrified.

Rick couldn't have been older than twenty-five. Bald patches covered his head from chemotherapy and his arms were bruised purple from IV needles. He kept staring at the giant machine behind Markus like it was either about to save his life or end it.

Maybe both.

Markus gave him a small smile.

"Welcome, Rick. This is an experimental cancer treatment."

The machine behind them powered up with a low mechanical whine.

Rick swallowed hard.

Markus leaned against the counter slightly.

"Would you like to go through with it?"

Rick looked down at his shaking hands.

"Yeah... yes, I want to do it."

For a second Markus didn't answer. He just watched him.

Everybody always looked the same before treatment.

Scared.

Hopeful.

Already halfway broken.

Markus nodded once.

"Okay then... let's get started."

Across the room a monitor flashed red for half a second before stabilizing again.

Nobody noticed except the camera mounted high in the corner.

The heavy doors sealed shut behind them with a hydraulic hiss.

And somewhere else in the building—

Someone started screaming.

Chapter 2 — Restricted Hallway

Red emergency lights painted the hallway in pulses.

Bright red.

Dark.

Bright red.

Dark.

Paperwork covered the floor like snow while two scientists screamed at each other beside a reinforced security door.

Jay Togay shoved Flake backward hard enough to slam him against the wall.

“NO! You need to stop—this isn’t what we made this for!”

Flake barely reacted.

His eyes looked dead tired.

Not sleepy.

Dead.

“I must find how to revert them...” he muttered. “How to resurrect living beings.”

Jay stared at him like he didn’t recognize him anymore.

“NO, FLAKE! There are innocent children here!”

Flake laughed once under his breath.

Not because it was funny.

Because he was losing it.

“Why, Jay? It’s not like you listen.”

Another red flash rolled across the hallway.

Jay clenched his fists.

“You’re talking about human testing like it’s nothing.”

Flake stepped closer.

His voice dropped quieter.

“Death is nothing.”

That sentence hung in the air longer than it should’ve.

Then finally Flake sighed and stepped away.

“Fine,” he said softly. “I will—for now.”

Jay watched him leave down the hallway while alarms echoed faintly through the building.

For the first time since joining the lab—

Jay felt afraid of him.

Chapter 3 — Miracles

The news called them miracle workers.

Children that should’ve died walked out healthy.

Parents cried in hospital hallways holding their kids like they were scared they’d disappear if they let go.

One little girl hugged Markus around the waist saying she didn’t feel sick anymore.

Jay laughed while helping another kid draw dinosaurs on a clipboard.

Nurses smiled more often now.

The lab became famous almost overnight.

But every time cameras flashed—

Flake stood in the background.

Watching.

Writing notes.

Never smiling.

Chapter 4 — Chris n’ Dip

Rainwater reflected city lights across the sidewalks while the three of them walked home after another fourteen hour shift.

Markus shoved his hands into his hoodie pockets.

“Yo, Jay.”

“Yeah, Mark?”

Markus looked up toward the dark sky between buildings.

“Ever wonder what would happen if something bad happened and we got blamed?”

Jay laughed instantly.

“Haha, no. Why’d you ask?”

Markus shrugged.

“Ah—no reason.”

Flake walked a few steps ahead of them completely silent until he suddenly pointed toward a glowing restaurant sign.

CHRIS N’ DIP.

“Yo y’all wanna get food from Chris n’ Dip? It’s right up the street.”

Jay grinned.

“HELL yeah.”

Markus nodded immediately.

The warm restaurant lights spilled onto the sidewalk as they stepped inside.

For a moment—

Everything felt normal again.

Chapter 5 — The Call

The waitress walked over carrying menus.

“Hey there, what can I get for you three?”

“Salmon and chips,” Markus answered.

“Salmon and chips, got it.”

She looked toward Jay.

“And for you, sir?”

“I’ll take the oni—”

Flake’s phone rang.

Everybody stopped talking.

Flake looked at the screen.

His expression changed instantly.

He answered slowly.

“Hello?”

The restaurant noise faded into the background.

Markus watched Flake’s hands start shaking.

“This is St. Mercy Hospital... are you Flake Groves?”

“...Yeah.”

A pause.

“We did everything we could.”

Flake’s face drained white.

Jay sat forward.

"What happened?"

The doctor kept talking quietly through the speaker.

"I'm sorry. He didn't make it."

Silence.

Just forks clinking somewhere in the distance.

Markus leaned closer.

"Yo... Flake? What's wrong?"

Flake stared at the table.

"M-my brother..." His voice cracked. "They couldn't save him."

Jay blinked.

"What? Is he okay?"

Flake looked up slowly.

"No."

Nobody moved.

"He died from leukemia."

The waitress awkwardly backed away.

"Uh... I'll give you guys a minute."

Jay immediately put a hand on his shoulder.

"Yo bro, I'm here for you."

Markus nodded.

"If you ever need us, talk to us."

Flake didn't answer.

He just stared at the floor while the lights overhead buzzed softly.

Like something inside him had already started breaking apart.

Chapter 6 — 8:00 AM

His garage smelled like burnt wires and stale energy drinks.

Computer monitors covered every wall.

Medical journals.

Body scans.

Research notes.

Failed equations scratched out violently in red marker.

Flake sat motionless in front of the screens while distorted audio played quietly through broken speakers.

Resurrection.

Cell restoration.

Neural repair.

Every search got more desperate.

His eyes turned bloodshot from staying awake all night.

The clock read:

3:14 AM.

4:52 AM.

6:37 AM.

7:59 AM.

The morning sunlight finally pushed through the garage window.
Flake looked horrible.
But he smiled anyway.
Because he thought he found something.

Chapter 7 — Quiet

Town Square felt too bright that morning.
People walked to work carrying coffee while buses hissed past puddles from last night's rain.
Markus spotted Flake standing near the fountain.
"You good, bro?"
No answer.
Jay walked beside him.
"You've been quiet all day, man. Talk to us."
Nothing.
Flake just kept walking toward the lab.
Not fast.
Not slow.
Like a corpse remembering how humans move.
Markus and Jay exchanged a look.
Something was wrong.
Really wrong.

Chapter 8 — The Break

The patient convulsed violently in the chair.
Monitors screamed.
"Vitals are dropping!"
"That spike shouldn't be happening!"
Jay turned toward Flake.
"Dude, stop!"
The patient started screaming loud enough to echo through the entire lab.
"PLEASE—HELP ME—"
Flake's hands shook uncontrollably.
Then suddenly—
The monitor flatlined.
One long tone filled the room.
Jay shoved him backward.
"YOU NEED TO FUCKING STOP—YOU'RE KILLING THEM!"
Something snapped inside Flake's face.
Not emotionally.
Literally.
Like every emotion disconnected at once.
"I'VE FUCKING HAD IT WITH EVERYONE IN THIS BULLSHIT PLACE!"
He pulled a handgun from his coat.
Everybody froze.

Then—
Gunshots.
Glass exploded.
People screamed.
Jay hit the floor clutching his chest.
Markus yelled in pain grabbing his bleeding arm.
Nurses ran for the exits while alarms flooded the building.
“CALL SECURITY!”
“GET DOWN!”
“Code red. Code red. All personnel evacuate.”
Flake stood motionless in the middle of the chaos breathing hard.
Then he looked at the bodies around him—
And calmly reloaded.

Chapter 9 — Attempt 943

Thirty-six patients died that night.
Flake cleaned every body himself.
Attempt 1.
Attempt 2.
Attempt 16.
Attempt 41.
Days blurred together underground while the city above had no idea what was happening beneath them.
Most subjects came back wrong.
Some screamed until their throats split open.
Some attacked the walls until their bones snapped.
Others just stared silently into corners—
Like they could see something standing there.
Attempt 943 succeeded.
Partially.
The body sat upright on the table twitching violently.
Its jaw unhinged too wide.
Black veins spread beneath pale skin.
Then it screamed.
Not human.
Not animal.
Something worse.
The creature broke free instantly.
Metal tore apart.
Lights shattered.
Flake shut off the breakers.
Darkness swallowed everything.
And in the silence—
Dozens of breathing sounds answered him back.

Chapter 10 — Day 7

Seven days after the massacre—

The lab no longer looked human.

Blood stains covered walls.

Ceiling lights flickered weakly above destroyed hallways.

Four hundred seventy-two test subjects had been brought in the previous day alone.

Only ten remained.

The final ten were personal.

People Flake actually knew.

People he refused to let stay dead.

He worked nonstop until his hands bled through his gloves.

One by one—

The bodies opened their eyes again.

Flake smiled weakly.

Then collapsed unconscious beside the machines.

Chapter 11 — The Unknown

The security doors exploded open.

Markus and Jay stormed inside carrying pistols.

Jay could barely walk correctly from the gunshot wounds.

“FLAKE!”

No answer.

Only distant screeching sounds deeper underground.

Flake stumbled through the testing grounds half delirious.

The emergency lights flashed red across rows of containment tanks.

Markus raised the gun.

“Don’t move!”

Flake turned around slowly.

For a second—

He almost looked normal again.

Then the gunshot echoed through the chamber.

Flake dropped instantly.

Dead before he hit the floor.

Silence.

Jay lowered his weapon breathing heavily.

Then suddenly—

The power came back on.

Every machine in the room activated at once.

Monitors flashed alive.

Containment doors unlocked.

Flake’s corpse twitched.

Markus froze.

“...Jay.”

Bones cracked loudly beneath Flake's skin.
His fingers bent backward.
His chest started moving again.
Slowly—
His eyes opened.
Pitch black.
Fully conscious.
Around him, dozens of creatures emerged from the darkness breathing in wet uneven sounds.
And Flake smiled.
Cut to black.
Police radios crackled faintly somewhere far above ground.
"Multiple casualties reported..."
"We found another body—"
"Get medical down here now—"
A stretcher wheel squeaked across tile floors.
Then—
Nothing.

Chapter 12 — Seven Days After

Seven days after the incident, nothing felt repaired.
The facility was still down there. Still breathing. Still wrong.
Inside the ruins, emergency lights flickered in and out of life, painting broken red across collapsed hallways and blood-smeared floors. Every flash made the place look alive again for a second before it died back into darkness.
Something moved through the corridor.
Slow footsteps. Wet breathing.
Flake Groves stopped in front of a cracked mirror.
What stared back didn't feel complete anymore.
One glowing eye. Black veins crawling under skin. A body that looked rebuilt instead of born.
He touched his face like he wasn't sure it was his.
"What... did I become?"
Something screamed deeper in the facility.
And it answered him without words.

Chapter 13 — Hospital Silence

Above ground, the world tried to act normal.
Jay woke up in a hospital bed like he'd been dropped back into reality without warning. Pain hit him instantly, sharp and heavy under bandages.
Markus was already there.
Jay's first word was Flake.
The room went quiet after that.
On the screen in the corner, news anchors talked about the massacre like it was distant history, even though it was still fresh enough to smell.
Over five hundred dead.

No explanation that made sense.
Just numbers that couldn't hold what actually happened.
Jay stared at the ceiling.
"We should've stopped him."
Markus didn't answer fast enough.
That was the answer.

Chapter 14 — The City Learns Fear

The city didn't recover.
It adapted.
Missing posters appeared overnight. Streets grew emptier. People stopped standing near windows after dark. Police checkpoints stayed active longer than they used to.
Curfew sirens rolled through the night like warnings that never turned off.
Radios repeated the same instructions.
Stay inside.
Avoid restricted zones.
Report anything unusual.
Nobody explained what "unusual" meant anymore.

Chapter 15 — Father

Flake went deeper underground.
The facility wasn't just destroyed. It had changed. Corridors led places that weren't on original plans. Walls felt closer. Air felt heavier.
The creatures were still alive.
Some crawled on ceilings. Some whispered in broken human voices. Some just watched him like they remembered something they couldn't say.
One stepped forward.
It didn't attack.
It spoke.
"Father..."
Flake froze.
For the first time since the incident, he didn't move at all.

Chapter 16 — NOVA DIVISION

At the surface, trucks surrounded the facility.
No lights. No warnings. Just control.
NOVA DIVISION had arrived.
Commander Elise Ward stood still as reports came in through her earpiece. No survivors confirmed. Unknown biological activity increasing below ground.
A soldier asked about Groves.
Elise didn't hesitate.
"Terminate on sight."
No emotion. No doubt.
Just procedure.

Chapter 17 — Memory Collapse

Flake found an old office.

Monitors still worked in fragments.

He saw them again.

Markus. Jay. Children laughing. Patients walking out healed. His brother smiling like nothing bad could ever exist.

Then it broke.

Glitches crawled across the screen like something trying to escape it.

Flake's hands shook uncontrollably.

"I tried to save you..."

He destroyed the monitor.

And the silence that followed felt heavier than sound.

Chapter 18 — First Contact

NOVA soldiers entered underground sectors.

Flashlights cut through darkness that didn't behave right.

One soldier stopped.

ATTEMPT 944 SUCCESS was carved into the wall.

Before he could speak—

The lights died.

Gunfire erupted.

Something moved across the ceiling too fast to track.

Then everything went quiet again.

Chapter 19 — Return

Jay left the hospital.

Markus followed without arguing.

Neither of them needed to say what they were going to do.

The drive back felt longer than it should've.

Like the road itself didn't want them there.

Jay finally spoke.

"If he's alive..."

Markus finished it.

"Then we end it."

Neither of them sounded certain anymore.

Chapter 20 — The Child

Deep inside quarantine zones, a child wandered in by mistake.

Something moved toward her from the dark.

Fast.

Before it could reach her, it hit the ground violently.

Flake stood over it.

Breathing hard.

The child stared at him.

“Monster...”

Flake looked down at his reflection in a puddle.

For a moment, he didn't argue.

Chapter 21 — PROJECT UNKNOWN

Far beneath everything, deeper than any recorded test zone, a sealed chamber activated itself.

No human input.

No authorization.

Just wake-up protocols that should never have restarted.

Sirens filled the structure.

“PROJECT UNKNOWN ACTIVE.”

Metal shifted.

Locks released.

And inside the chamber, something massive opened its eyes.

It didn't struggle.

It didn't wake slowly.

It was already aware.

And it was smiling.

Chapter 21 — The Rain Line

Rain hit the broken concrete like something trying to erase what had happened here.

The Groves Research Facility stood half-collapsed behind police tape that no longer meant anything. Wind pulled at it constantly, snapping it against twisted metal and shattered walls.

It looked abandoned.

But it wasn't empty.

Jay stood at the edge of the perimeter staring at the building like it owed him something.

Markus stood beside him in silence.

Zah checked a handheld recorder, watching readings scroll across the screen.

“You're sure he's still in there?” she asked.

Jay didn't look away from the facility.

“If he is... we end this tonight.”

Markus hesitated.

That hesitation was becoming normal.

Something about the building didn't feel like ruins.

It felt awake.

Chapter 22 — Lockdown

They stepped inside.

The doors shut behind them before anyone could react.

A heavy metal slam echoed through the structure like a final decision.

Then silence.

Then darkness.

Red emergency lights flickered on slowly, like the building was choosing whether to acknowledge them.

Jay turned immediately.

“NO—NO NO NO!”

The exit wouldn’t move.

Markus ran his hands along the wall.

“There’s gotta be another way out.”

Zah already knew the answer.

“This isn’t manual,” she said quietly. “It’s automated lockdown.”

Every exit confirmed what they were already realizing.

They hadn’t entered the facility.

They had been accepted by it.

Chapter 23 — The Empty System

The deeper they went, the more wrong it felt.

Hallways stretched too far for their memory of the building. Lights flickered even where power should’ve been gone.

Wheelchairs sat in corridors facing walls.

Beds were still made.

Coffee still sat half-finished on desks like someone had just stepped away.

Zah stopped at a panel.

“The system’s not off,” she whispered. “Something’s cycling power through sections.”

A loud metallic bang echoed somewhere ahead.

All three froze.

Zah turned off her flashlight.

The darkness became absolute.

Nothing moved.

But nothing left either.

Chapter 24 — The Room That Stayed

They found the safe room by accident.

Or maybe it found them.

A hidden lounge still powered. Still stocked. Canned food. Blankets. Old monitors glowing faintly with standby light.

Markus let out a breath he didn’t realize he was holding.

“Okay... this works.”

Jay lowered himself onto a chair.

“We stay here tonight.”

Zah didn’t sit.

“This room wasn’t abandoned,” she said. “Someone maintained it.”

That line changed the mood instantly.

They barricaded the door anyway.

Not because they felt safe.

Because they didn’t know what else to do.

Chapter 25 — Day Three

Time inside didn't move correctly.

They slept in shifts. Drank bitter coffee. Ate food that tasted like nothing.

Zah recorded everything.

Jay got quieter.

Markus stared at walls for too long.

Then the network died.

Wi-Fi cut out completely.

Jay hit the router.

"Seriously?"

Nothing changed.

Then the monitor flickered.

And turned on.

Chapter 26 — The Feed

A security camera feed appeared on the screen.

Static.

Then half an image.

Flake's face.

Still.

Wrongly calm.

Behind him stood something that shouldn't have been able to stand like that.

A shadowed creature smiling.

Flake looked directly into the camera.

"Hi, Jay."

Jay stumbled backward instantly.

Zah froze.

Markus didn't move at all.

The feed cut.

And the room felt smaller afterward.

Chapter 27 — 2:00 AM

The first breach happened at night.

Zah woke first.

Scraping noise outside the door.

Something circling the room.

Heavy breathing.

Stopping directly in front of them.

Jay reached for a weapon he didn't fully believe would help.

Zah whispered:

"Don't move."

A loud hit struck the door.

Then another.

Metal shifting.
The lock mechanism started to fail.
Zah killed the lights.
Everything went black.
Something entered briefly.
Stopped.
Left again.
Nobody spoke after that.
Not for a long time.

Chapter 28 — Time Doesn't Pass Right

3:00 AM.
5:00 AM.
Time felt like it was repeating itself instead of moving forward.
Zah's recordings became unstable. Audio cracked with interference.
"It's learning the patterns," she whispered. "It comes at the same times."
Jay held a pipe he never used.
Markus didn't sit anymore.
He just watched the door like it might blink first.

Chapter 29 — Morning Without Light

At 6:00 AM they left the room.
The building was still alive in the worst way.
They found binders. Logs. Medical notes. Storage rooms still filled with supplies.
Zah collected everything she could carry.
"If we get out," she said, "this proves everything."
A scream cut through the hallway.
All three stopped.
Not from one direction.
From everywhere at once.

Chapter 30 — Markus Taken

Flake appeared without warning.
No footsteps.
No sound.
Just presence.
Markus reacted first.
"RUN!"
Zah grabbed Jay and pulled him back.
Markus stayed behind them.
Trying to hold the line.
Trying to be the barrier.
Flake moved anyway.
Too fast to understand.

Markus was grabbed and dragged into darkness.
His scream cut off halfway.
Then nothing.
Just empty hallway again.
Zah didn't look back.
Neither did Jay.

Chapter 31 — What Was Left

They returned later.
Too late.
Only drag marks remained.
No blood.
No sign of struggle after a point.
Like he had been taken somewhere the building refused to show them.
Zah dropped to her knees but kept the recorder running.
“We can't stop now,” she said quietly. “This has to mean something.”
Her voice didn't sound like confidence anymore.
Just necessity.

Chapter 32 — Watching

At 7:00 AM, Flake stood outside their safe room.
Not moving.
Not attacking.
Just waiting.
For thirty minutes.
Then he turned and walked away.
A nearby monitor turned on by itself.
News broadcast filled the screen.
Reports of ongoing killings.
Names that didn't feel real anymore.
The facility being mentioned like it was still part of the city instead of something buried underneath it.

Chapter 33 — The Call

The office phone rang violently.
Zah answered immediately.
Static filled the line.
Then Markus' voice.
Weak.
Broken.
“Run...”
The line distorted.
Screaming followed.
Metal crashing.

Something dragging him away again.
Then silence.
The line went dead.
Zah stood holding the receiver for a long time after that.
Then she slowly set it down.
And the building stayed quiet.
Like it was waiting for what she would do next.

Chapter 34 — The Shifting Structure

They woke up wrong.
Not injured. Not asleep. Just placed.
The world around them no longer matched what they remembered of the facility. Walls didn't align with physics anymore. Corridors bent into themselves. Staircases led into collapsed floors that shouldn't exist, like the building had forgotten its own blueprint and started improvising.
Nothing stayed still long enough to trust.
Even silence felt active.
It stretched too long between sounds, like something was listening through it.
Jay moved first, slow and tense, gun low but ready. Markus followed behind him, still recovering, every step heavier than the last. Zah Groves stayed slightly ahead, eyes constantly scanning the environment like he was trying to decode it rather than survive it.
The facility changed as they moved.
Doors sealed behind them without touching anything. Walls shifted subtly when they weren't looking directly at them. Hallways that should've ended simply... didn't.
Zah stopped once, recording the walls.
"This isn't collapse," he said quietly. "It's rebuilding itself."
Markus swallowed hard.
"We're inside something that's still working."
Jay didn't like that sentence.
"Then we find the exit before it decides we don't leave."
Nobody argued with that.

Chapter 34 — Markus

They found him in a lower stairwell buried under broken concrete and twisted metal.
Markus Oakley was alive.
Barely.
Pinned in place, breathing shallow, like his body hadn't fully decided whether to keep going or not.
Jay didn't hesitate. He pulled debris off him with shaking urgency while Zah searched nearby storage rooms, finding old medical supplies still somehow intact.
They patched him quickly. Not properly. Just enough.
Markus coughed, eyes half-open.
"I thought I was gone..."
Jay didn't look away from him.
"You're still here. That's enough."

It wasn't comfort.
It was fact.

Chapter 35 — The Preserved Section

The deeper they went, the more unnatural the contrast became.
Entire rooms remained untouched.
Lights working. Supplies arranged neatly. Systems still running at low power.
Clean.
Maintained.
Wrong.
Zah stopped in front of one of the doors.
"This isn't abandoned," he said. "Someone is controlling what stays intact here."
That made everything worse.
Because it meant the building wasn't random.
It was selective.

Chapter 36 — The Blood Hallway

The corridor ahead stretched too far.
Walls were covered in heavy blood splatter, dried in layers like it had happened repeatedly in the same place.
Behind a sealed door, children were screaming.
Jay froze instantly.
Markus turned toward it slowly.
Zah didn't move, but his recorder was still running.
"We can't ignore that," Jay said.
Markus nodded once.
"We check it."
Zah hesitated.
"That sound isn't stable. It's layered."
The door wouldn't open.
Not because it was locked.
Because it didn't want to.

Chapter 37 — The Blue Fragment

Zah found it buried in rubble.
A blue diagram fragment embedded in broken concrete.
He cleaned it carefully.
It wasn't just a map.
It was layered.
Hidden vents. Sealed chambers. Depths below recorded floors.
The facility was not one structure.
It was several stacked systems hiding inside each other.
Zah's voice lowered.
"This place has more levels than we can see."

Chapter 38 — The Vent System

They entered through narrow maintenance vents.

Metal tunnels stretched into darkness, bending sound strangely. Every movement felt too loud, too exposed.

The deeper they crawled, the more it felt like the structure was guiding them instead of the other way around.

Eventually, the vent opened into a preserved room.

Too clean.

Too intentional.

Chapter 39 — The Bookcase

A bookshelf stood in the center.

Everything around it was destroyed.

The shelf was not.

Perfectly intact.

Unmarked.

On the floor beneath it were circular markings spaced with precision.

Zah studied them closely.

“These aren’t random,” he said. “They’re routes. Something moves through here.”

Chapter 40 — The System Beneath Furniture

Inside the bookshelf were embedded data logs.

Zah tried to pull one free.

It didn’t move.

He pulled harder.

A mechanical grinding sound echoed through the walls.

Markus stepped back immediately.

“That’s not furniture.”

Jay exhaled slowly.

“It’s a system.”

The bookshelf shifted slightly.

Like it had heard them.

Chapter 41 — The Hidden Door

The structure split open behind the bookshelf.

A hidden doorway.

They tried forcing it first.

Nothing.

Zah pulled out a small key.

Old. Personal. Tied to Flake’s family line.

He hesitated.

Then inserted it.

It turned.

The door unlocked.

Chapter 42 — The Capsule Room

Inside were four wall capsules.

One blinked red.

One was empty.

One contained Flake Groves.

Dead.

Wired into machines. A hole through his body. Kept in place like storage instead of death.

The other capsules held malformed human bodies.

Not fully transformed.

Not fully anything.

One of them slowly turned its head.

Its eyes tracked them.

Jay spoke quietly.

“This is where they were kept...”

Nobody answered.

They left immediately.

Chapter 43 — The Fall

The floor collapsed without warning.

The entire structure gave out beneath them.

They fell into darkness.

Impact came with water and stone.

Zah was separated in the fall.

The building swallowed the sound of their descent.

Chapter 44 — The Cave System

Zah woke alone.

A massive underground cave system stretched in every direction.

Echoes didn't behave correctly here.

They lingered too long.

He moved carefully.

Eventually, he found Jay and Markus again.

Jay looked at him like he wasn't sure it was real.

“I've seen this place before... with Flake.”

Markus nodded slowly.

“Then it leads somewhere important.”

Chapter 45 — The Blind Thing

Deep scratch marks led them forward.

Then light appeared ahead.

Small. Artificial.

They moved toward it.

The passage collapsed before they reached it.
Zah stopped instantly.
“Something is moving through here.”
Alarms suddenly triggered somewhere far above.
A creature escaped containment.
Blind.
It hunted sound.
They encountered it in a wide broken chamber.
Jay froze.
Markus threw debris to the side to mislead it.
It followed the noise instantly.
They escaped by silence alone.

Chapter 46 — The Exit That Wasn't
They found a barricaded structure.
Wood nailed over stone.
Zah tore it apart piece by piece until it gave way.
The structure collapsed immediately after.
They fell again.
Downward.

Chapter 47 — The Lake Cabin
They emerged near a mountain lake.
A cabin stood waiting.
Supplies inside: axe, fishing rod, firewood.
No explanation.
Just survival tools.
They lit a fire.
Night came fast.
And the forest beyond the lake stayed still for too long.

Chapter 48 — The First Night Outside
Something appeared in the trees.
Not fully visible.
Not fully present.
It watched them.
Then vanished.
The cabin had no door.
It had been ripped away.
They stayed inside anyway.
Because leaving felt worse.

Chapter 49 — Morning
Dead animals surrounded the cabin.

No blood trail leading away.
Just sudden ends.
They split tasks.
Fishing. Wood. Fire.
Normal survival roles forced onto an abnormal situation.
Markus stared at the lake.
“Is this even safe?”
Jay didn’t look up.
“We eat or we don’t last.”

Chapter 50 — Zah
Zah went into the forest alone.
Tree markings led deeper than the others could follow.
He followed them anyway.
Something moved behind him.
Then grabbed him.
The forest went silent.
Later, he returned crawling.
Barely alive.
His leg was destroyed.
His voice barely worked.
“Run.”
They didn’t ask questions.
They just stabilized him.
Barely.

Audio: distant wind through broken metal. Soft static. A heartbeat that doesn’t match any of them.
Then a voice, faint, almost human.
Flake Groves: (distorted whisper) “I remember... something.”
Cut in.

Chapter 51 — LAKE MORNING AFTER THE NIGHT
The lake is still.
Too still.
The cabin door is gone, just ripped clean off like it was never meant to protect anything. Ash from the fire drifts slowly through the air even though there’s no wind.
Jay sits awake, holding a metal pipe in both hands.
Markus is barely conscious near the fire, breathing shallow but alive.
Zah Groves is wrapped in makeshift bandages, one leg badly damaged, shaking every time he tries to move.
Nobody speaks at first.
Because speaking feels like it would make things worse.
Then—

A sound from the tree line.

Footsteps.

Slow.

Controlled.

Jay stands instantly.

“Don’t move.”

Something steps out.

Flake Groves.

But not fully the creature anymore.

Not fully human either.

His body flickers between states, like reality can’t decide what he is. Black veins still crawl under his skin, but they pulse weaker now. His glowing eye is dimmer.

He looks at them.

Not attacking.

Just watching.

Chapter 52 — NO FIRST STRIKE

Nobody shoots.

Nobody moves.

Even Jay doesn’t raise his weapon.

Flake tilts his head slightly.

Flake Groves: (quiet, broken) “Why didn’t you run?”

Markus pushes himself up slightly, pain in every movement.

Markus: “Because we’re done running.”

Flake’s breathing changes.

Like that answer hit something deeper than expected.

Zah watches carefully.

Zah Groves: “You’re still in there.”

Flake doesn’t respond.

But he doesn’t leave either.

Chapter 53 — THE DECISION

They bring him closer to the fire.

Not trusting him.

But not attacking him.

The tension is unbearable.

Jay keeps his distance.

“You killed people,” Jay says quietly.

Flake doesn’t deny it.

“I know.”

Silence stretches.

Then Markus speaks.

“You weren’t like this before.”

Flake’s hands shake slightly.

"I don't know what I am anymore."

Zah studies him closely.

"It's still you. Just... unstable."

Flake reacts to that word.

"Unstable."

Like he recognizes it.

Like it hurts.

Chapter 54 — THE SHIFT

Flake suddenly collapses to one knee.

Not an attack.

A breakdown.

His body spasms like something inside him is fighting itself.

Black veins pulse rapidly.

His eye flickers between glowing and normal.

Flake Groves: (strained) "It's still in me..."

Jay steps forward slightly, unsure.

"What is?"

Flake grabs his own head.

"The system... the thing under the facility... it never left."

Zah's expression changes.

Zah Groves: "PROJECT UNKNOWN."

Flake looks up at that word.

Like it triggers memory.

Chapter 55 — CONNECTION

Zah slowly kneels in front of him, careful.

Not close enough to be unsafe.

But close enough to be heard.

Zah Groves: "Listen to me. You built it. That means part of you controls it."

Flake shakes his head violently.

Flake Groves: "No... I didn't build THAT."

Markus leans forward slightly.

"Then what did you build?"

Flake pauses.

Long.

Then softer.

"...a cure."

Silence.

Jay looks away.

That word feels like a lie now.

Chapter 56 — INSIDE THE FIGHT

Flake suddenly jerks backward.

His body convulses.
The creature inside him tries to take over.
His voice splits.
Flake Groves: (glitching) “GET OUT—”
Then something deeper.
Unknown Voice: (same tone, layered) “YOU ARE PART OF US.”
Flake screams.
The ground cracks slightly beneath him.
Jay reacts instantly.
“MOVE!”
He slams Flake to the ground, pinning him down.
Not violently.
Restraining.
Markus joins immediately.
Zah pulls out a stabilizing injector from emergency supplies found earlier.
Zah Groves: “Hold him still!”
Jay: “He’s going to kill us!”
Markus: “No—he’s fighting it!”
Flake’s body shakes violently.
Black veins spread rapidly.
Then—
Zah injects something into his neck.
A synthesized stabilizer from old lab compounds.
Flake screams.
Then—
Stops.

Chapter 57 — QUIET RETURN

Silence.
Flake’s breathing is heavy.
But human again.
His glowing eye dims further.
The black veins stop moving.
He collapses forward, barely conscious.
Flake Groves: (weak whisper) “I... can see again.”
Jay slowly lets go.
But doesn’t trust it yet.
Markus exhales like he’s been holding his breath for hours.
Zah watches carefully.
“It’s not gone,” Zah says. “But it’s suppressed.”
Flake closes his eyes.
“I don’t feel it watching anymore.”

Chapter 58 — THE FIRST NORMAL MOMENT

Hours pass.
They don't move far.
Just stay near the fire.
Flake sits slightly apart from them.
Still not fully trusted.
But no longer attacked.
Jay eventually sits down too, far enough away to react if needed.
Markus speaks quietly.
"You remember us?"
Flake nods slowly.
"...yes."
Pause.
"I remember everything."
That hits harder than expected.
Because it means he remembers what he did too.

Chapter 59 — THE TRUTH RETURNS

Zah pulls out recovered notes from earlier expeditions.
Facility data fragments.
Capsule logs.
PROJECT UNKNOWN references.
Flake looks at them and flinches.
Flake Groves: "That chamber... wasn't supposed to open."
Jay: "It did."
Flake shakes his head.
"No... it wasn't awake yet."
Markus: "What is it?"
Flake hesitates.
For the first time, he looks afraid.
"...something that learned from me."

Chapter 60 — DISTANT SIGNAL

The fire flickers.
A faint sound echoes from deep beneath the ground.
Metal shifting.
Like something far below is reacting to Flake being conscious again.
Flake hears it immediately.
He stiffens.
Flake Groves: (low whisper) "It felt that."
Jay stands.
"Felt what?"
Flake doesn't answer.
Because he doesn't want to say it out loud.

Chapter 61 — ENDING SHIFT

Night falls again.

Flake sits awake, staring at the fire.

His breathing is steady now.

Almost normal.

But not fully.

Markus watches him from a distance.

Zah writes notes quietly.

Jay stays alert, refusing to sleep.

Flake whispers to himself.

Flake Groves: "If I stay like this... it won't stay asleep."

He looks at them.

"I think I'm the lock... and the key."

Chapter 62 - The End Game

Deep underground.

The massive containment system from Episode 4 stirs.

Something inside moves closer to the surface.

Not breaking out.

Responding.

A mechanical voice activates.

SYSTEM STATUS: STABILITY LINK RESTORED

A pause.

Then:

SUBJECT FLAKE GROVES — RECONNECTED

The chamber lights flicker.

Something inside smiles.

A low mechanical humming. Deep underground resonance. Like a machine breathing through concrete.

Flake Groves: faint, "It's still running..."

A second later, his voice corrects itself.

Flake Groves: "...I can hear it."

Chapter 63 — RETURN TO THE DEPTHS

Morning at the lake feels wrong.

The fire is still warm, but nothing about the world feels safe anymore.

Flake stands at the edge of the water.

For a moment he looks normal.

Then his body flickers.

Black veins briefly crawl under his skin before fading again.

Jay watches him closely.

"You good?"

Flake hesitates.

Flake Groves: "No."

A pause.

"...but I'm here."

Markus adjusts his gear slowly, still recovering but steadying himself.

"We go back in?"

Zah Groves is already checking recovered data fragments.

"Yes. If we don't shut it down, it keeps expanding."

Flake looks toward the forest line.

Like something is calling him from underneath it.

"...I know the way."

Chapter 64 — DESCENT BACK INTO THE MAZE

They return.

The forest path feels different this time.

Less natural.

More structured.

Like the ground remembers where they stepped before.

The entrance to the facility is still broken open, but it doesn't feel like an entrance anymore.

It feels like an artery.

Flake pauses before entering.

His hand shakes slightly.

Black veins flicker up his arm for a second.

Then stop.

Flake Groves: (quiet) "Don't let me go too far ahead."

Jay doesn't respond.

But he doesn't argue either.

Chapter 65 — SYSTEM WAKE

Inside, everything reacts to Flake.

Not violently.

Not passively.

Recognizing.

Lights flicker in sequence as they pass.

Doors hesitate before closing.

Zah notices immediately.

Zah Groves: "It's reacting to him."

Markus: "Like he's part of it."

Flake hears that.

He doesn't deny it.

"I am," he says quietly.

Then, softer:

"...and I'm not supposed to be."

Chapter 66 — FIRST SHUTDOWN NODE

They reach an old control sector buried beneath collapsed labs.
Terminals still function.
Barely.
Zah connects a portable device.
Data floods in.
PROJECT UNKNOWN systems.
Capsule networks.
Creature propagation lines.
Markus leans in.
“This is all still active...”
Flake steps closer.
The screen flickers.
For a second, the text changes:
SUBJECT DETECTED
Flake immediately steps back.
His body glitches again.
Half-human.
Half-something else.
Jay grabs his arm.
“Hey—stay with us.”
Flake closes his eyes.
“...I’m trying.”

Chapter 67 — SYSTEM INTERFERENCE

As Zah begins shutdown sequences, alarms don’t activate.
Instead, something worse happens.
Silence.
Then voices through the walls.
Not speakers.
Not radios.
Just structure.
Unknown Voice: “YOU ARE INSIDE US.”
Flake grips his head.
Black veins pulse violently.
Flake Groves: (strained) “It knows we’re disconnecting parts of it...”
Markus: “Can we stop it?”
Zah Groves: “Yes. But it will resist.”
Jay loads his weapon.
“Then we make it hurt.”
Flake looks at him sharply.
“No,” Flake says.
Jay pauses.
Flake Groves: “If it resists too hard... it wakes the rest.”
That silence lands heavy.

Chapter 68 — FLOORS OF MEMORY

They move deeper.

The facility begins showing memory-like distortions.

Hallways that resemble old lab days.

Echoes of people who are no longer alive.

Flake sees flashes.

His brother.

The original lab.

The first experiments.

He stops walking.

Flake Groves: (quiet) "I started this before I knew what it was."

Markus: "Then you can stop it now."

Flake shakes his head slightly.

"...I don't know if that's true."

But he keeps moving anyway.

Chapter 69 — SECOND SHUTDOWN NODE

They reach another core system.

This one is deeper.

Older.

Zah works fast now.

Zah Groves: "If this goes down, half the network collapses."

Jay watches corridors constantly.

Flake stands still.

His body flickers more often now.

From Human to broken to human again.

Each shift weaker than the last.

Markus notices.

"You're fading."

Flake nods.

"I know."

A pause.

"But so is it."

Zah triggers the shutdown.

The system responds instantly.

The entire structure trembles.

Something below them screams.

Not sound.

Pressure.

Chapter 70 — THE LINK BREAK

Flake suddenly collapses.

Not unconscious.

Disconnected.
His eyes open but unfocused.
Unknown Voice: "RETURN TO FUNCTION."
His body spasms.
Black veins spread again rapidly.
Jay moves immediately.
"FLAKE!"
Markus grabs him too.
Zah shouts:
"Hold him down—don't let him sync!"
They restrain him.
Flake fights it.
Not violently.
Internally.
Like two versions of him are tearing apart.
Flake Groves: (broken) "I don't want to go back..."
Then softer.
"...I don't want to disappear."
Zah injects stabilizing code serum into his system.
A pulse runs through him.
The black veins stop.
Silence returns.
Flake gasps.
Then slowly:
"...I'm still here."

Chapter 71 — THE SYSTEM FAILS BACK

Shutdown continues.
Entire sections of the facility collapse into inactivity.
Lights die in sequence.
Creature signals fade.
The structure feels less alive with every passing minute.
But not gone.
Just sleeping.
Zah watches readings carefully.
Zah Groves: "We didn't kill it."
Markus: "We shut it down."
Zah shakes his head.
"No... we forced it to dream."
That statement doesn't comfort anyone.

Chapter 72 — SURFACE RETURN

They return to the lake area.
The forest feels quieter.

Not safe.
Just paused.
Flake stands at the edge of the water again.
This time, no flicker.
Just exhaustion.
Jay sits nearby, finally lowering his guard slightly.
Markus leans against a tree.
Zah organizes data fragments.
For the first time in a long time—
there is no immediate threat.
Only survival.
Flake speaks softly.
“...it’s still under us.”
Markus nods.
“Then we keep it down.”
Flake looks at them.
Something changes in his expression.
Not fear.
Not guilt.
Something else.
Understanding.

Chapter 73

Deep below.
The shutdown network stabilizes.
PROJECT UNKNOWN enters dormant state.
But inside the core chamber—
something remains awake.
Not fully active.
Not fully asleep.
It watches the systems fail around it.
Then speaks once.
Unknown Voice: (calm) “THE SURFACE THINKS IT WON.”
A pause.
Then softer:
“...GOOD.”

THE ADVENTURE HAS JUST BEGUN...

